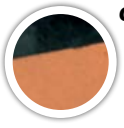
BEYOND ISRO'S BLUEPRINT

DECADES OF STATE-LED SPACE EXPLORATION BUILT THE FOUNDATION FOR A PRIVATE SPACETECH INDUSTRY THAT MUST NOW BUILD ON IT TO CREATE TECHNOLOGY AND BUSINESSES OF ITS OWN

BY **PRADIP K. SAHA**



CONTROL TO ALL STATIONS

There is a hold observed at T-minus five minutes.

All stations are requested to be on standby mode."

The countdown had stopped.

On July 18, Vikram-1, India's first private orbital-class rocket, built by Skyroot Aerospace, was scheduled to lift off at 11:30 am from Sriharikota's First Launch Pad. Hundreds of visitors, including children, had gathered to watch the launch. Thousands more were following the broadcast across the country.

The sudden pause in the countdown shook up the mood inside the launch control centre at Skyroot Aerospace's Infinity Campus in Hyderabad. Engineers rose from their consoles. Phones turned busy. People scrambled between workstations, checking screens, whispering to one another. The tension was palpable.

Beyond Skyroot's campus, the hold message sent goosebumps through India's entire space community. Watching the broadcast in Chennai, Srinath Ravichandran, Co-founder and CEO of Agnikul Cosmos, felt a familiar knot in his stomach.

"We had to abort two launches. One of them was T-129 seconds and the other was T-11 seconds. So, when they had that delay because of a hold, it reminded me of our own launch and our own countdown as well," says Ravichandran, who co-founded Agnikul in 2017 after leaving a career on Wall Street. "It means a